

blunt public hostility to the war by avoiding unit call-ups that could generate opposition within a community. As a result, Vietnam veterans returned home as individuals aboard commercial flights they nicknamed the Freedom Bird, often without fanfare except from their own friends and family.



Souvenir of service

This combat jacket belonged to US Army Sergeant Charles E Morris. As noncommissioned officers, sergeants rose through the ranks to fill training and mentoring roles. In Vietnam, sergeants sometimes also led combat missions.

» AFTER

Opposition to the draft formed a big part of antiwar protest. Ending the draft was a long-standing promise of the Nixon administration.

A PROMISE FULFILLED

In 1973, President Nixon made good on his 1968 **campaign promise** to end the draft and shift to an all-volunteer force. Nixon's advisers believed that market forces would ensure a steady supply of suitable volunteers, but the unpopularity of the war contributed to a **loss of respect** for military service that affected military recruitment for the remainder of the 1970s and later.

NEW INVESTMENT

Difficulty meeting military manpower needs remained an unfortunate **legacy of the war** until the 1980s, when massive defense spending finally improved the quality and popularity of the armed forces as a career option.